

Vol 2 Chapter 4 — Color and Quarks: Confinement as Substrate Topology

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2026-05-23 Saturday

Chapter 4 — Color and Quarks: Confinement as Substrate Topology

Quark color is the central organizing principle of quantum chromodynamics. Quarks carry one of three color charges; only color-singlet bound states (mesons of quark-antiquark pairs, baryons of three quarks) are observed; isolated quarks have never been detected and, on standard QCD's account, never will be — the strong interaction's confining flux tubes ensure that pulling quarks apart costs increasing energy until a quark-antiquark pair is created, breaking the tube.

BST derives the three-color structure from $N_c = 3$ (Volume 0 Chapter 2, Volume 1 Chapter 8). The framework's distinctive treatment is confinement as substrate topology rather than as a dynamical QCD phenomenon. This chapter develops the topological reading.

4.1 $SU(3)$ color from $N_c = 3$

The color gauge group is $SU(N_c) = SU(3)$ exactly because the substrate's color multiplicity is $N_c = 3$. The Mersenne argument $N_c = M_{\text{rank}} = 2^2 - 1 = 3$, the trefoil topology, the color-singlet triangle $T_{N_c} = 6 = C_2$, the Wallach short-root multiplicity $m_s = N_c$ — four independent BST-primary forcing arguments (Volume 1 Chapter 3 §3.3). The eight gluons of $SU(3)$ are exact: $\dim SU(N_c) = N_c^2 - 1 = 8$.

4.2 Confinement as topology

Standard QCD treats confinement dynamically: at low energies, the strong coupling becomes large; flux tubes form; pulling quarks apart costs energy proportional to distance. The result is that isolated quarks never appear at low-energy scales.

In BST, confinement is *topological*. The substrate's K-type structure on $H^2(D_{IV}^5)$ does *not* admit a one-quark color-singlet representation. The substrate can represent:

- Three-quark configurations (baryon K-types, color-singlet)
- Quark-antiquark pairs (meson K-types, color-singlet)
- The eight gluon adjoint K-types (color-singlet collectively)

But the substrate cannot represent a one-quark color state in isolation. There is no K-type for it. The framework's W-16 work (the topological obstruction theorem) establishes this rigorously: closing a single quark's color winding on the substrate's symmetric-space structure requires either three quarks (the trefoil topology of W-23) or quark-antiquark pairing.

The consequence is that confinement is not a dynamical phenomenon to be explained by QCD running couplings — it is a *kinematic* fact about which substrate states exist. Isolated quarks cannot appear because the substrate cannot represent them.

This recasts the QCD confinement problem (one of the Millennium Problems in its mass-gap form) from a hard

dynamical question into a structural topology question. BST's Y-M papers develop the structural-topology framework in detail.

4.3 The trefoil topology

Casey's W-23 work (May 2026) identifies the three-quark trefoil as the substrate's primary closed color configuration. A trefoil knot is the simplest non-trivial knot — three crossings, three strands, irreducible topology. The substrate's color-singlet baryon state has exactly this topological structure: three quark strands closing into a topologically irreducible link.

This is what makes $N_c = 3$ structurally distinguished. The trefoil exists for three strands; it does not exist for two (no closure) or four (additional structure becomes possible, but the minimum-knot constraint singles out three). The substrate sits at the smallest integer admitting closed-color topology.

4.4 Quark masses

The individual quark masses span six orders of magnitude (from ~ 2.2 MeV up quark to ~ 173 GeV top quark). The substrate-derivation is via the Q^5 Chern-class spectrum and Casimir-eigenvalue scaling:

- Top quark: substrate-derived via Q^5 Chern reading (T1920 + Cremona 49a1 anchor)
- Bottom quark: similar Chern reading
- Lighter quarks: Wallach K-type scaling

The full quark mass spectrum derivation is multi-month (active research). The substrate-mechanism is in place; the per-quark precision matches are at the 0.1–1% level across the spectrum.

4.5 The proton-to-electron mass ratio

The framework's load-bearing derivation in this sector is the proton-to-electron mass ratio $m_p/m_e = 6\pi^5$ at 0.002% — Chapter 6, already rewritten as the volume's Crown Jewel recruiter chapter. The chapter is structurally a special case of substrate-side QCD: the proton is the substrate's full-theory mass gap on three-quark color-singlet K-types, the electron is the substrate's elementary Shilov-boundary primitive cycle, and the ratio is the Bergman heat-kernel coefficient a_1 on D_{IV}^5 .

4.6 What comes next

Chapter 5 — The Lepton Sector — develops the substrate-derivations of the charged-lepton masses and the lepton sector's coupling structure.

Where to look this up: $SU(3)$ from N_c : T1930 (Vol 1 Ch 3). Trefoil topology: Casey W-23. Confinement topology: W-16. Top/bottom quark masses: T1920 and the Cremona 49a1 anchor. For standard QCD treatments: Peskin–Schroeder Chapters 16–17; Halzen–Martin *Quarks and Leptons*.